# Supplementary Information for When better baselines make worse models: a target-design principle for delta learning

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## Scope and Reporting Conventions

This supplement asks how target construction changes the difficulty of learning molecular energies and their transfer between chemical domains. SchNet and GemNet are evaluated on the same 13 target definitions, with independent GNN seeds 101, 102, and 103 for every target. Each run is evaluated on the tmQM test split and on QM9 using its own best-validation checkpoint. The 78 main runs are supplemented by four DFTB runs: two targets, two architectures, and seed 101 only.

Unless stated otherwise, errors are in Hartree (Ha), and uncertainty denotes the sample standard deviation of independently evaluated seed-level scores. Predictions are not averaged into an ensemble. A smaller error measures better performance on that target; it does not by itself explain the physical origin of the improvement.

DFTB is shown in magenta and marked † in every comparison figure. It is a supporting control, not a member of the primary target panel. DFTB is excluded from all pooled correlations, regression fits, target-ranking statistics, leave-one-target-out analyses, and primary-panel summaries. Its own single-run metrics and explicitly matched-subset comparisons are reported separately. No across-seed error bar is assigned to a single DFTB run.

The target-panel table defines the identifiers used in plots. BoE-lin means the linear composition reference; BoE-MLP denotes the alternative nonlinear composition residual. An unsubscripted BoE reference is linear. In particular, the BoE-MLP target is fitted directly from $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$, not from the linear-BoE residual.

Table S1: Complete target and evaluation panel. Counts are molecules per seed; both architectures use the same counts. DFTB$^{\dagger}$ rows are display-only controls for pooled analyses.

| ID | Target | Seeds | Train | Validation | Test | QM9 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| T1 | $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T2 | $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T3 | $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T4 | $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T5 | $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T6 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T7 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 3 | 56,830 | 7,104 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T8 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 3 | 56,821 | 7,103 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T9 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 3 | 56,821 | 7,103 | 7,104 | 130,807 |
| T10 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 3 | 56,821 | 7,103 | 7,104 | 128,988 |
| T11 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 3 | 56,821 | 7,103 | 7,104 | 128,988 |
| T12 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 3 | 56,821 | 7,103 | 7,104 | 128,988 |
| T13 | $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 3 | 56,821 | 7,103 | 7,104 | 128,988 |
| T14† | $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 1 | 56,540 | 7,068 | 7,068 | 130,797 |
| T15† | $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 1 | 56,540 | 7,068 | 7,068 | 130,797 |

The architecture comparison is matched within every target: both architectures use its identical target values and split memberships. The entire panel does not have an identical training cohort across targets. The six descriptor residuals use 56,821 training and 7,103 validation molecules, whereas the other main targets use 56,830 and 7,104. All 13 main targets share the same 7,104 test molecules. DFTB has a separate success-filtered cohort.

# Supplementary Section 1: Target Preprocessing and Scale Controls

## Supplementary Note 1: Direct Preprocessing Controls

Composition referencing removes a large, learnable contribution to the atom-referenced DFT energy. With a linear BoE reference, test MAE falls from $0.019917 \pm 0.000178$ to $0.015648 \pm 0.000077$ Ha for SchNet and from $0.013360 \pm 0.000423$ to $0.009448 \pm 0.000469$ Ha for GemNet. The nonlinear BoE baseline narrows the residual further, but downstream errors increase to $0.024672 \pm 0.000112$ and $0.022380 \pm 0.000452$ Ha, respectively. A smaller residual distribution therefore does not guarantee an easier regression problem.

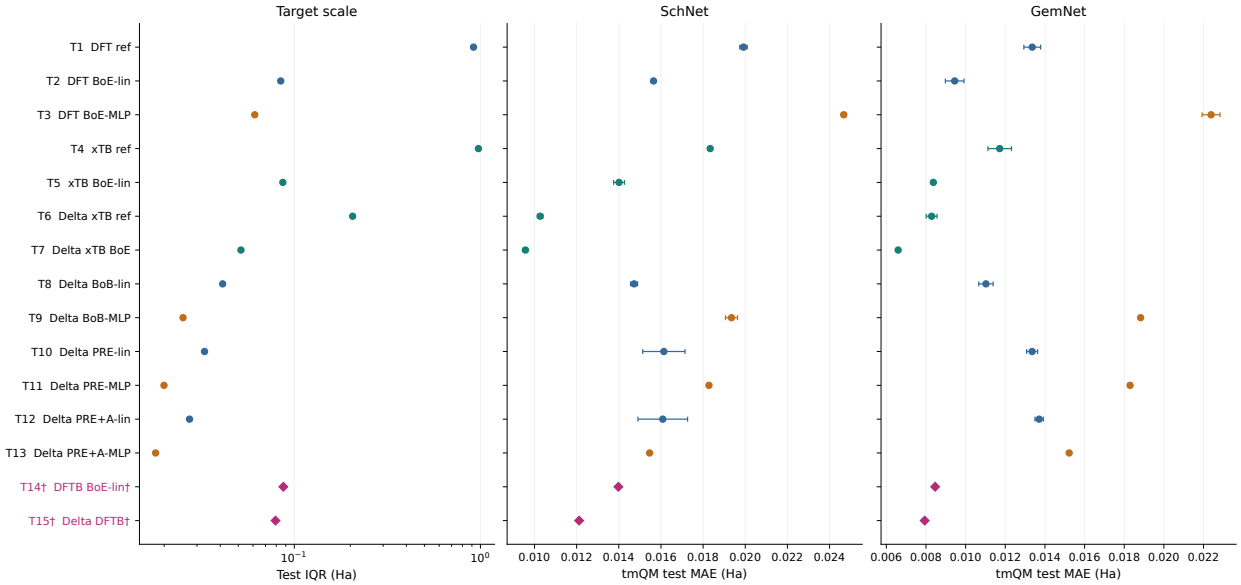



Figure S1: **Target scale and test error.** Test IQR and tmQM test MAE for all targets. Error bars are sample SD over three GNN seeds. Magenta DFTB† points are single-seed, reduced-cohort controls.

Table S2: Native-target test MAE (Ha), mean ± sample SD across seeds 101, 102, and 103. DFTB$^{\dagger}$ has seed 101 only. xTB and DFTB direct-energy rows measure their own energies, not DFT reconstruction error.

| Target | SchNet test MAE | GemNet test MAE |
|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.019917 ± 0.000178 | 0.013360 ± 0.000423 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.015648 ± 0.000077 | 0.009448 ± 0.000469 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.024672 ± 0.000112 | 0.022380 ± 0.000452 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.018337 ± 0.000099 | 0.011718 ± 0.000595 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.014011 ± 0.000258 | 0.008372 ± 0.000031 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.010269 ± 0.000128 | 0.008286 ± 0.000273 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.009569 ± 0.000101 | 0.006596 ± 0.000048 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.014724 ± 0.000167 | 0.011024 ± 0.000363 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.019347 ± 0.000287 | 0.018826 ± 0.000056 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.016139 ± 0.001004 | 0.013355 ± 0.000278 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.018278 ± 0.000070 | 0.018293 ± 0.000090 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.016086 ± 0.001178 | 0.013710 ± 0.000212 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.015462 ± 0.000035 | 0.015222 ± 0.000006 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.013980 | 0.008462 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.012119 | 0.007936 |

Table S3: Downstream training, validation, and test MAE (Ha). Training MAE averages all logged optimizer-step MAEs during epoch 80 as the weights evolve. Validation MAE is the best recorded validation score for each run, and test MAE is evaluated with that validation-selected checkpoint. Thus the training column describes the final epoch, rather than inference with frozen weights. Entries are means and sample SDs across seeds 101, 102, and 103. DFTB controls report seed 101 only.

| Target | Training (epoch 80) | Validation (selected) | Test (selected) |
|---|---|---|---|
| **GemNet** | | | |
| $E_{\text{ref}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | $0.00996 \pm 0.00124$ | $0.01310 \pm 0.00052$ | $0.01336 \pm 0.00042$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | $0.00179 \pm 0.00037$ | $0.00930 \pm 0.00046$ | $0.00945 \pm 0.00047$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-MLP}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | $0.00131 \pm 0.00002$ | $0.02190 \pm 0.00044$ | $0.02238 \pm 0.00045$ |
| $E_{\text{ref}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.00946 \pm 0.00033$ | $0.01183 \pm 0.00075$ | $0.01172 \pm 0.00059$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.00154 \pm 0.00001$ | $0.00853 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.00837 \pm 0.00003$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.00409 \pm 0.00027$ | $0.00810 \pm 0.00020$ | $0.00829 \pm 0.00027$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref,BoE}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.00100 \pm 0.00008$ | $0.00653 \pm 0.00012$ | $0.00660 \pm 0.00005$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{BoB}}$ | $0.00102 \pm 0.00005$ | $0.01123 \pm 0.00025$ | $0.01102 \pm 0.00036$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{BoB}}$ | $0.00077 \pm 0.00033$ | $0.01853 \pm 0.00015$ | $0.01883 \pm 0.00006$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{PRE}}$ | $0.00075 \pm 0.00010$ | $0.01380 \pm 0.00020$ | $0.01335 \pm 0.00028$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{PRE}}$ | $0.00355 \pm 0.00029$ | $0.01817 \pm 0.00012$ | $0.01829 \pm 0.00009$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{PRE+A}}$ | $0.00071 \pm 0.00003$ | $0.01373 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01371 \pm 0.00021$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{PRE+A}}$ | $0.00050 \pm 0.00019$ | $0.01563 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01522 \pm 0.00001$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{DFTB†}}$ | 0.00177 | 0.01130 | 0.00846 |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref,BoE}}^{\text{DFTB†}}$ | 0.00128 | 0.00920 | 0.00794 |
| **SchNet** | | | |
| $E_{\text{ref}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | $0.02286 \pm 0.00087$ | $0.01940 \pm 0.00010$ | $0.01992 \pm 0.00018$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | $0.00650 \pm 0.00036$ | $0.01533 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01565 \pm 0.00008$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-MLP}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | $0.00544 \pm 0.00025$ | $0.02377 \pm 0.00015$ | $0.02467 \pm 0.00011$ |
| $E_{\text{ref}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.02133 \pm 0.00007$ | $0.01833 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01834 \pm 0.00010$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.00686 \pm 0.00015$ | $0.01387 \pm 0.00012$ | $0.01401 \pm 0.00026$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.01087 \pm 0.00011$ | $0.01007 \pm 0.00015$ | $0.01027 \pm 0.00013$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref,BoE}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | $0.00377 \pm 0.00029$ | $0.00947 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.00957 \pm 0.00010$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{BoB}}$ | $0.00355 \pm 0.00025$ | $0.01443 \pm 0.00012$ | $0.01472 \pm 0.00017$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{BoB}}$ | $0.00307 \pm 0.00036$ | $0.01893 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01935 \pm 0.00029$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{PRE}}$ | $0.00289 \pm 0.00020$ | $0.01597 \pm 0.00015$ | $0.01614 \pm 0.00100$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{PRE}}$ | $0.00198 \pm 0.00020$ | $0.01817 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01828 \pm 0.00007$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{PRE+A}}$ | $0.00295 \pm 0.00051$ | $0.01547 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01609 \pm 0.00118$ |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{PRE+A}}$ | $0.00140 \pm 0.00008$ | $0.01587 \pm 0.00006$ | $0.01546 \pm 0.00003$ |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{DFTB†}}$ | 0.00682 | 0.01400 | 0.01398 |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref,BoE}}^{\text{DFTB†}}$ | 0.00495 | 0.01170 | 0.01212 |

Direct xTB and DFTB energy-prediction rows describe how well each GNN learns the semiempirical energy itself. They are not DFT reconstruction errors. For a residual $\Delta^b = y - b$, in contrast, the stacked predictor $\hat{y} = b + \widehat{\Delta}^b$ satisfies

$$\hat{y} - y = \widehat{\Delta}^b - \Delta^b. \tag{S1}$$

Residual MAE and RMSE are exactly those of the reconstructed parent-energy prediction on the same molecules. This equivalence does not extend to $R^2$, Pearson correlation, or rank correlation without reconstructing the parent energy.

## Supplementary Note 2: What Scale Normalization Removes

For $y' = ay + c$, with $a \neq 0$, the IQR and a consistently rescaled prediction error change by $|a|$. For a fixed molecular graph,

$$\mathrm{IQR}(y') = |a|\mathrm{IQR}(y), \quad D_{\text{raw}}(y') = a^2 D_{\text{raw}}(y), \quad D_{\text{IQR}}(y') = D_{\text{IQR}}(y). \tag{S2}$$

IQR-normalized roughness therefore removes a pure change of units or amplitude. A fitted baseline is not generally a uniform rescaling: it can change molecular ordering, tail structure, and local differences.

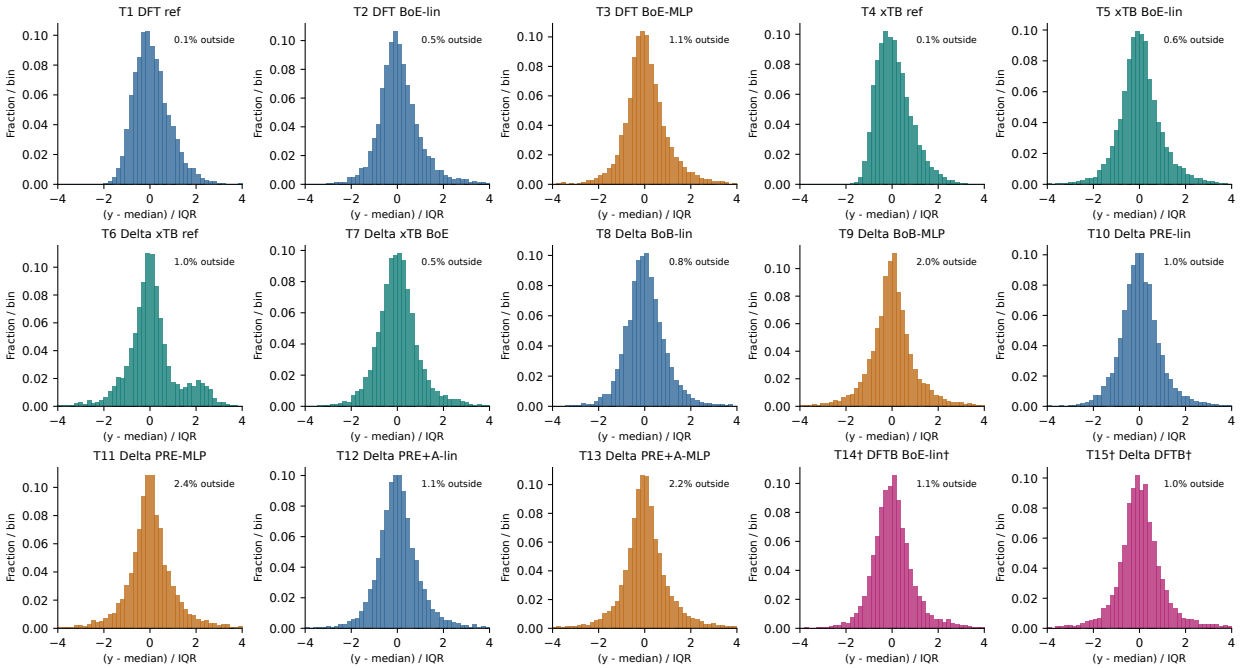



Figure S2: **Standardized test-target distributions.** Targets are centred by their test median and divided by their test IQR. Bin heights use the full test target population; annotations give fractions outside the displayed interval. DFTB† uses its valid subset.

This invariance is algebraic; it does not establish that independently optimized networks attain identical normalized errors. Nor does it eliminate correlations introduced by using a related scale factor on both diagnostic axes. Supplementary Note 7 examines that issue directly.

# Supplementary Section 2: Baseline-Selection Diagnostics

## Supplementary Note 3: Baseline Accuracy and Downstream Error

A useful baseline must do more than reproduce the parent energy accurately: the remaining signal must also be learnable by the downstream architecture. The baseline-score table reports frozen-baseline errors on test molecules. Test scores were calculated after fitting and did not select baseline parameters.

Table S4: Frozen baseline performance against the DFT-BoE parent (Ha). Errors and correlations refer to the baseline alone; test labels are used here only for post-training evaluation. DFTB$^{\dagger}$ uses its valid subset.

| Residual | Test MAE | Test RMSE | Pearson $r$ | Spearman $\rho$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{BoB}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.029315 | 0.047333 | 0.839 | 0.823 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{BoB}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.021124 | 0.041346 | 0.881 | 0.901 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.024967 | 0.057663 | 0.771 | 0.893 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.018746 | 0.068647 | 0.731 | 0.934 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.021128 | 0.047002 | 0.847 | 0.923 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.016335 | 0.053602 | 0.811 | 0.950 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 0.035716 | 0.050873 | 0.830 | 0.787 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 0.058773 | 0.086576 | 0.560 | 0.504 |

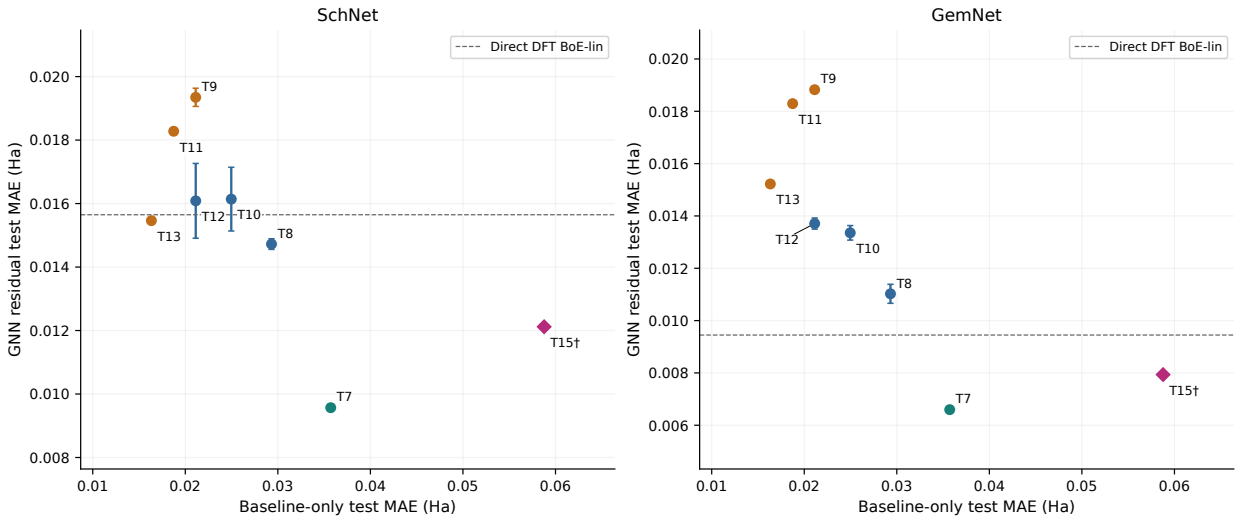



Figure S3: **Baseline accuracy versus downstream test error.** Each point pairs baseline-only test MAE with the GNN residual test MAE. Dashed lines show direct DFT-BoE learning. Error bars are GNN seed SD; DFTB† is a separate single-seed control.

More accurate descriptor baselines need not yield better downstream predictors. BoB, PRE, and PRE+A MLPs have smaller baseline errors than their corresponding linear models, yet none of their residual targets beats direct DFT-BoE learning for GemNet. For SchNet, linear BoB improves on direct learning, whereas linear PRE and PRE+A do not improve the mean test MAE. The latter two targets also have larger seed variability than most other SchNet targets.

The xTB BoE-referenced residual has the smallest mean tmQM test MAE in the 13-target panel for both architectures: $0.009569 \pm 0.000101$ Ha for SchNet and $0.006596 \pm 0.000048$ Ha for GemNet. Relative to direct DFT-BoE learning, these are 1.635-fold and 1.432-fold lower errors. This is an empirical target-design result, not proof of a particular electronic or geometric mechanism.

## Supplementary Note 4: Descriptor Baseline Capacity

The linear and MLP descriptor models have the same parent target and, within each descriptor family, the same inputs and split memberships. Changing the fitting model tests baseline capacity without changing the DFT reference convention. Comparing descriptors under the common 512–128-hidden-unit MLP design tests information content, although input dimensions and total parameter counts differ.

MLP-PRE and MLP-PRE+A concentrate much of the residual near zero, but downstream errors and roughness do not decrease in proportion to the IQR. Their in-domain performance should not be extrapolated to QM9: fixed descriptor baselines can behave differently outside the tmQM domain. The transfer evaluation below tests this directly.

# Supplementary Section 3: QM9 Transfer Controls

## Supplementary Note 5: Complete Transfer Evaluation

Every main GNN seed is evaluated on QM9 without refitting the GNN or baseline. Native-target MAE is first reported on all molecules for which the target is defined: 130,807 for most targets, 128,988 for PRE and PRE+A residuals, and 130,797 for DFTB. Missing descriptor and DFTB rows are not imputed. Because cohorts differ, native-score tables document coverage but are not exact all-target, matched-cohort comparisons.

A second analysis reconstructs the common DFT-BoE parent and evaluates all main DFT-prediction routes on the same 128,988 molecules. Direct xTB and DFTB energy predictors are not DFT-prediction routes and do not enter these parent-energy tables. The displayed DFTB residual uses its 128,978-molecule intersection with this cohort. An additional exact-mask comparison with direct DFT and xTB appears in Supplementary Note 8.

For each seed, the oracle mean-shift diagnostic subtracts the mean prediction error on the evaluated QM9 cohort,

$$\hat{y}_i^{\text{shifted}} = \hat{y}_i - \frac{1}{N}\sum_{j=1}^{N}(\hat{y}_j - y_j). \tag{S3}$$

This uses QM9 reference labels and is not a deployable, uncalibrated prediction. It removes constant bias, but not ordering errors, heteroscedastic scatter, or outliers. It minimizes squared error over constant shifts, not necessarily MAE. Raw transfer errors remain essential.

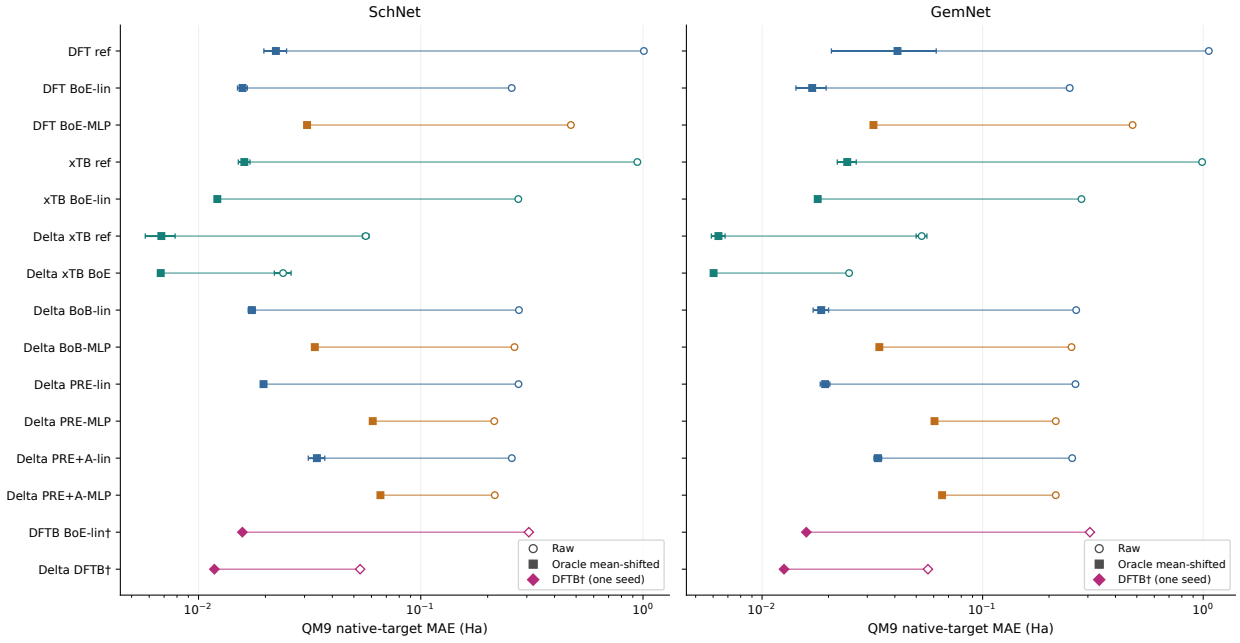



Figure S4: **Raw and oracle-shifted QM9 errors.** Open and filled symbols show native-target raw and shifted MAE; lines join the two diagnostics. Main results are three-seed means with sample SD. DFTB† is shown separately in magenta.

Table S5: SchNet QM9 native-target MAEs (Ha). Main targets: three independent seed scores, mean ± sample SD; DFTB$^{\dagger}$: seed 101. Native cohorts differ as listed. Shifts are estimated from the evaluated QM9 labels, not a separate calibration set.

| Target | N | Raw MAE | Oracle-shift MAE |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 130,807 | 1.009072 ± 0.005934 | 0.022291 ± 0.002609 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 130,807 | 0.256637 ± 0.004093 | 0.015778 ± 0.000802 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 130,807 | 0.473662 ± 0.009143 | 0.030793 ± 0.000568 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.942905 ± 0.001125 | 0.016076 ± 0.000972 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.274700 ± 0.002912 | 0.012149 ± 0.000225 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.056567 ± 0.001925 | 0.006805 ± 0.001043 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.024017 ± 0.002079 | 0.006760 ± 0.000192 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.276571 ± 0.002836 | 0.017383 ± 0.000645 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.264029 ± 0.002472 | 0.033360 ± 0.000369 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 128,988 | 0.275298 ± 0.002464 | 0.019612 ± 0.000547 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 128,988 | 0.214158 ± 0.000980 | 0.060797 ± 0.000118 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 128,988 | 0.256813 ± 0.001379 | 0.034096 ± 0.002906 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 128,988 | 0.215363 ± 0.000066 | 0.065843 ± 0.000111 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 130,797 | 0.306405 | 0.015751 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 130,797 | 0.053349 | 0.011783 |

Table S6: GemNet QM9 native-target MAEs (Ha). Main targets: three independent seed scores, mean ± sample SD; DFTB$^{\dagger}$: seed 101. Native cohorts differ as listed. Shifts are estimated from the evaluated QM9 labels, not a separate calibration set.

| Target | N | Raw MAE | Oracle-shift MAE |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 130,807 | 1.060215 ± 0.018798 | 0.041115 ± 0.020489 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 130,807 | 0.248256 ± 0.006282 | 0.016878 ± 0.002639 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 130,807 | 0.478472 ± 0.004472 | 0.031996 ± 0.000350 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.988524 ± 0.003253 | 0.024332 ± 0.002402 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.280595 ± 0.003342 | 0.017877 ± 0.000265 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.052928 ± 0.002964 | 0.006344 ± 0.000454 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.024815 ± 0.000231 | 0.006029 ± 0.000117 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.265518 ± 0.002632 | 0.018540 ± 0.001494 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 130,807 | 0.253024 ± 0.005363 | 0.034020 ± 0.000691 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 128,988 | 0.263566 ± 0.000964 | 0.019325 ± 0.000974 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 128,988 | 0.214647 ± 0.000882 | 0.060508 ± 0.000347 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 128,988 | 0.254705 ± 0.002866 | 0.033508 ± 0.001345 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 128,988 | 0.214623 ± 0.000429 | 0.065508 ± 0.000444 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 130,797 | 0.306466 | 0.015873 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 130,797 | 0.056495 | 0.012578 |

## Parent-Energy Reconstruction and Trend Fidelity

Equation S1 allows raw MAE to be scored in residual space. Parent-energy $R^2$ and Kendall $\tau$ require reconstruction first. For $E_{\mathrm{ref}}$ and the nonlinear BoE route, the frozen linear DFT-BoE term is subtracted after reconstruction so that every route refers to the same parent quantity.

Table S7: SchNet transfer after reconstruction onto the common DFT-BoE parent. Primary routes use the identical 128,988-molecule descriptor-common QM9 cohort; DFTB$^\dagger$ uses its 128,978-molecule intersection. RMSE and $R^2$ are means of seed-level oracle-shifted metrics. Kendall ordering is shift-invariant.

| Route | Oracle MAE | RMSE | $R^2$ | Kendall $\tau$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.020707 ± 0.002107 | 0.037080 | 0.467 | 0.749 ± 0.008 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.015634 ± 0.000814 | 0.028811 | 0.681 | 0.746 ± 0.015 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.030699 ± 0.000419 | 0.043151 | 0.285 | 0.549 ± 0.034 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.006603 ± 0.001017 | 0.009128 | 0.967 | 0.898 ± 0.013 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.006647 ± 0.000190 | 0.009381 | 0.966 | 0.895 ± 0.001 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.017229 ± 0.000583 | 0.030164 | 0.650 | 0.718 ± 0.012 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.033290 ± 0.000453 | 0.045189 | 0.216 | 0.473 ± 0.009 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.019612 ± 0.000547 | 0.032431 | 0.596 | 0.687 ± 0.002 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.060797 ± 0.000118 | 0.108187 | -3.495 | 0.506 ± 0.006 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.034096 ± 0.002906 | 0.066634 | -0.709 | 0.734 ± 0.002 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.065843 ± 0.000111 | 0.117543 | -4.306 | 0.710 ± 0.000 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.011623 | 0.016650 | 0.893 | 0.810 |

Table S8: GemNet transfer after reconstruction onto the common DFT-BoE parent. Primary routes use the identical 128,988-molecule descriptor-common QM9 cohort; DFTB$^\dagger$ uses its 128,978-molecule intersection. RMSE and $R^2$ are means of seed-level oracle-shifted metrics. Kendall ordering is shift-invariant.

| Route | Oracle MAE | RMSE | $R^2$ | Kendall $\tau$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.039317 ± 0.018274 | 0.062145 | -0.697 | 0.651 ± 0.029 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.016407 ± 0.002413 | 0.030401 | 0.643 | 0.726 ± 0.048 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.031678 ± 0.000363 | 0.044438 | 0.242 | 0.547 ± 0.024 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.006311 ± 0.000461 | 0.008690 | 0.971 | 0.896 ± 0.009 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.005982 ± 0.000095 | 0.008393 | 0.973 | 0.901 ± 0.001 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.018193 ± 0.001493 | 0.032728 | 0.587 | 0.698 ± 0.030 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.033881 ± 0.000583 | 0.045824 | 0.193 | 0.494 ± 0.029 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.019325 ± 0.000974 | 0.032730 | 0.588 | 0.703 ± 0.017 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.060508 ± 0.000347 | 0.107942 | -3.475 | 0.502 ± 0.008 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.033508 ± 0.001345 | 0.066759 | -0.712 | 0.738 ± 0.007 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.065508 ± 0.000444 | 0.117164 | -4.272 | 0.711 ± 0.001 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.012526 | 0.018161 | 0.873 | 0.790 |

On the matched main cohort, both xTB residual formulations retain substantially smaller oracle-shifted errors than the descriptor-MLP residuals. The BoE-referenced xTB route gives approximately 0.00665 Ha for SchNet and 0.00598 Ha for GemNet, with Kendall $\tau$ near 0.895 and

0.901. The atom-referenced xTB residual is also competitive; composition referencing does not uniformly improve every transfer metric for both architectures.

MLP-PRE and MLP-PRE+A have oracle-shifted errors near 0.061–0.066 Ha and negative parent-energy $R^2$, despite small in-domain residual widths. PRE+A can retain a moderate Kendall ordering while having poor RMSE and $R^2$: rank fidelity does not protect against large amplitude errors or outliers. These failures limit claims that a flexible fitted baseline necessarily improves transfer.

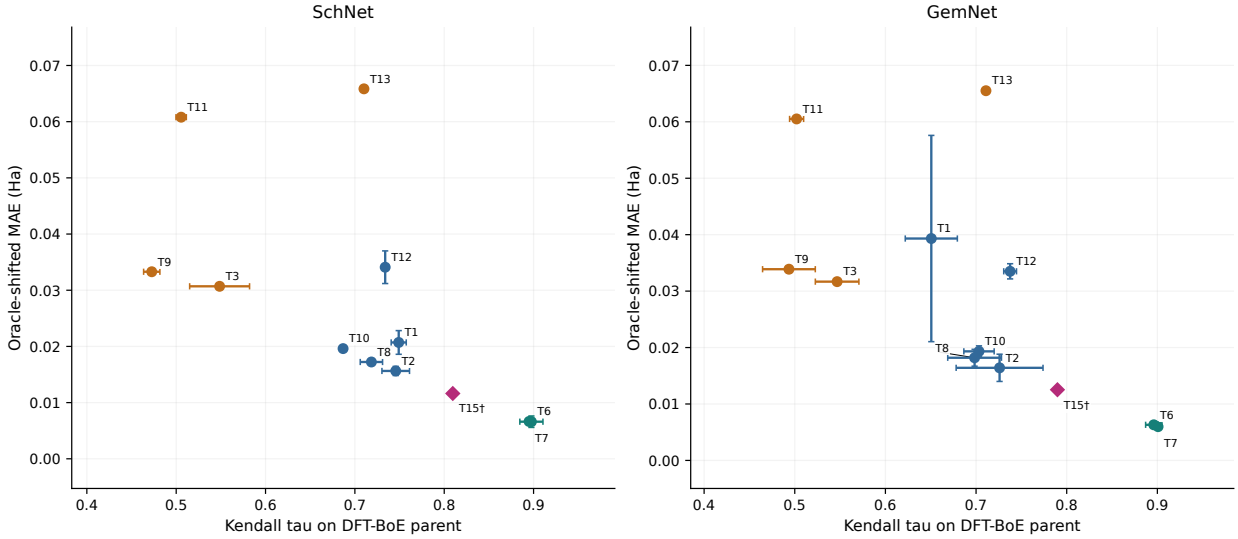



Figure S5: **Trend fidelity and remaining QM9 error.** Kendall $\tau$ versus oracle-shifted MAE after DFT-BoE reconstruction. Main routes use 128,988 common molecules; DFTB† uses its 128,978-molecule intersection and is not pooled with the main routes.

# Supplementary Section 4: Architecture Controls and Roughness

## Supplementary Note 6: Matched Architecture Panels

The roughness analysis uses all 13 main targets for both architectures. SchNet's proxy is PRE, and GemNet's proxy is PRE+A. These are fixed geometric proxies, not learned network representations. Pairwise message passing can encode more complex environments through multiple layers; PRE is not an exact representation of everything SchNet can learn.

The primary graphs use the 7,104 test molecules shared by all 13 targets. Standardized descriptors define cosine $k = 10$ neighbours. Unique undirected edges receive locally scaled Gaussian weights. For target $y$,

$$D_{\mathrm{raw}}(y) = \frac{\sum_{\{i,j\}\in\mathcal{E}} w_{ij}(y_i - y_j)^2}{\sum_{\{i,j\}\in\mathcal{E}} w_{ij}}, \qquad D_{\mathrm{IQR}}(y) = \frac{D_{\mathrm{raw}}(y)}{\mathrm{IQR}_{\mathrm{test}}(y)^2}. \tag{S4}$$

The normalized response is $n\text{-MAE}_{\mathrm{test}} = \mathrm{MAE}_{\mathrm{test}}/\mathrm{IQR}_{\mathrm{test}}(y)$. Test error, its scale denominator, and roughness use the same test cohort. Molecular descriptors alone define graph edges and weights; test labels supply the target differences and IQR after models are frozen. Validation is used for model selection and learning-rate scheduling, not the reported performance or roughness. This is a retrospective cross-target diagnostic, not a prospectively validated model-selection rule; using these test results to select future models would require a new independent evaluation set.

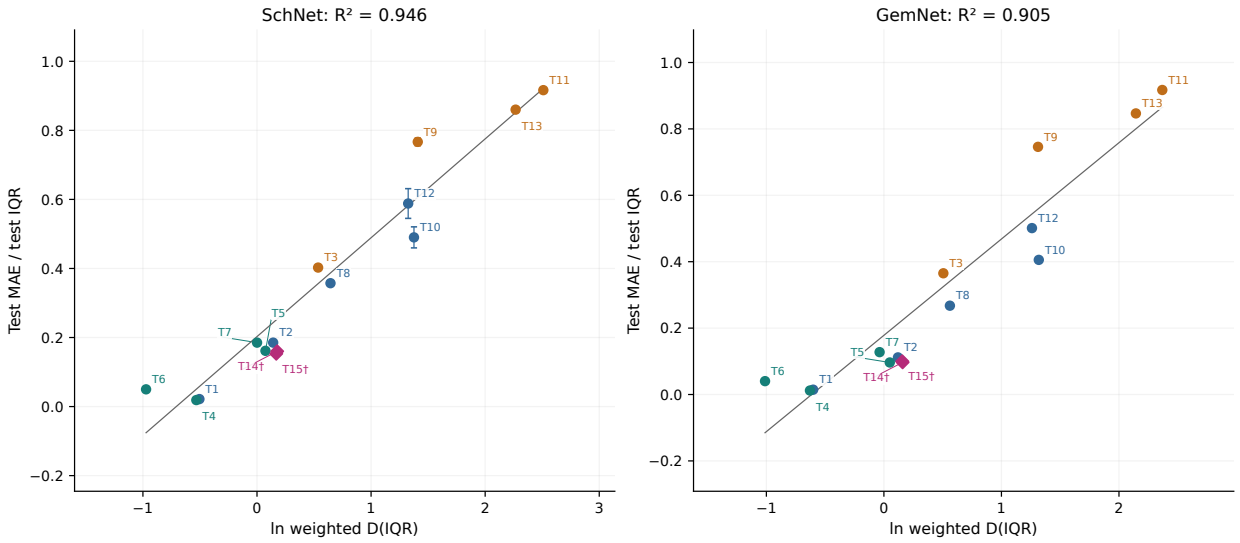



Figure S6: **Weighted test roughness versus normalized test error.** Lines fit the 13 main target means only. Error bars are three-seed SD divided by the fixed test IQR. DFTB† uses valid-subset test graphs and is excluded from fits and $R^2$.

Table S9: Architecture-proxy roughness and normalized test errors. Primary graph: 7,104 common test molecules; DFTB$^{\dagger}$ graph: 7,068 DFTB-valid test molecules. Each error and roughness uses its matching test IQR. DFTB positions are visual controls, not members of the regression.

| Target | Graph IQR (Ha) | PRE $D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ | PRE+A $D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ | SchNet $n$-MAE | GemNet $n$-MAE |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.918321 | 0.6036 | 0.5477 | 0.0217 | 0.0145 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.084504 | 1.1522 | 1.1271 | 0.1852 | 0.1118 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.061288 | 1.7086 | 1.6583 | 0.4026 | 0.3652 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.975633 | 0.5875 | 0.5330 | 0.0188 | 0.0120 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.086765 | 1.0771 | 1.0512 | 0.1615 | 0.0965 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.205796 | 0.3782 | 0.3637 | 0.0499 | 0.0403 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.051679 | 1.0005 | 0.9640 | 0.1852 | 0.1276 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.041208 | 1.9043 | 1.7533 | 0.3573 | 0.2675 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.025236 | 4.0925 | 3.7107 | 0.7666 | 0.7460 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.032934 | 3.9588 | 3.7353 | 0.4901 | 0.4055 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.019944 | 12.3036 | 10.6818 | 0.9165 | 0.9172 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.027351 | 3.7630 | 3.5243 | 0.5881 | 0.5012 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.017979 | 9.6504 | 8.5331 | 0.8600 | 0.8467 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.087331 | 1.1936 | 1.1725 | 0.1601 | 0.0969 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.079243 | 1.1839 | 1.1693 | 0.1529 | 0.1001 |

The descriptive semi-log fits are

$$n\text{-MAE}_{\mathrm{SchNet}} = 0.203 + 0.286 \ln D_{\mathrm{IQR}}, \qquad R^2 = 0.946, \tag{S5}$$

$$n\text{-MAE}_{\mathrm{GemNet}} = 0.178 + 0.290 \ln D_{\mathrm{IQR}}, \qquad R^2 = 0.905. \tag{S6}$$

Kendall $\tau$ is 0.872 for SchNet and 0.821 for GemNet over the 13 target means. These fits summarize the present panel; 39 GNN runs per architecture do not constitute 39 independent target-design observations.

## Supplementary Note 7: Normalization and Panel Sensitivity

A high correlation between $D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ and $n$-MAE can partly arise because both contain an inverse target IQR. We therefore repeat the analysis with unnormalized test MAE, unnormalized test roughness, and test-variance-normalized roughness. All variants use the same test graphs; only normalization changes. DFTB is excluded throughout.

Table S10: Cross-target associations with test error. S: SchNet; G: GemNet. Roughness is logarithm-transformed. DFTB is excluded from every row; N counts targets, not seeds. $R^2$ is in-sample, not cross-validated.

| Comparison | N | S $r$ | S $R^2$ | S $\tau$ | G $r$ | G $R^2$ | G $\tau$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Shared test IQR | 13 | 0.972 | 0.946 | 0.872 | 0.951 | 0.905 | 0.821 |
| Unnormalized error | 13 | 0.245 | 0.060 | 0.231 | 0.576 | 0.332 | 0.487 |
| Unnormalized roughness | 13 | -0.633 | 0.401 | -0.564 | -0.587 | 0.345 | -0.590 |
| Neither axis IQR-normalized | 13 | 0.259 | 0.067 | 0.128 | -0.137 | 0.019 | -0.154 |
| Variance-normalized roughness | 13 | 0.436 | 0.190 | 0.410 | 0.334 | 0.111 | 0.282 |
| DFT-BoE + seven residuals | 8 | 0.966 | 0.933 | 0.929 | 0.954 | 0.909 | 0.786 |
| Six descriptor residuals | 6 | 0.919 | 0.844 | 0.867 | 0.905 | 0.820 | 0.733 |

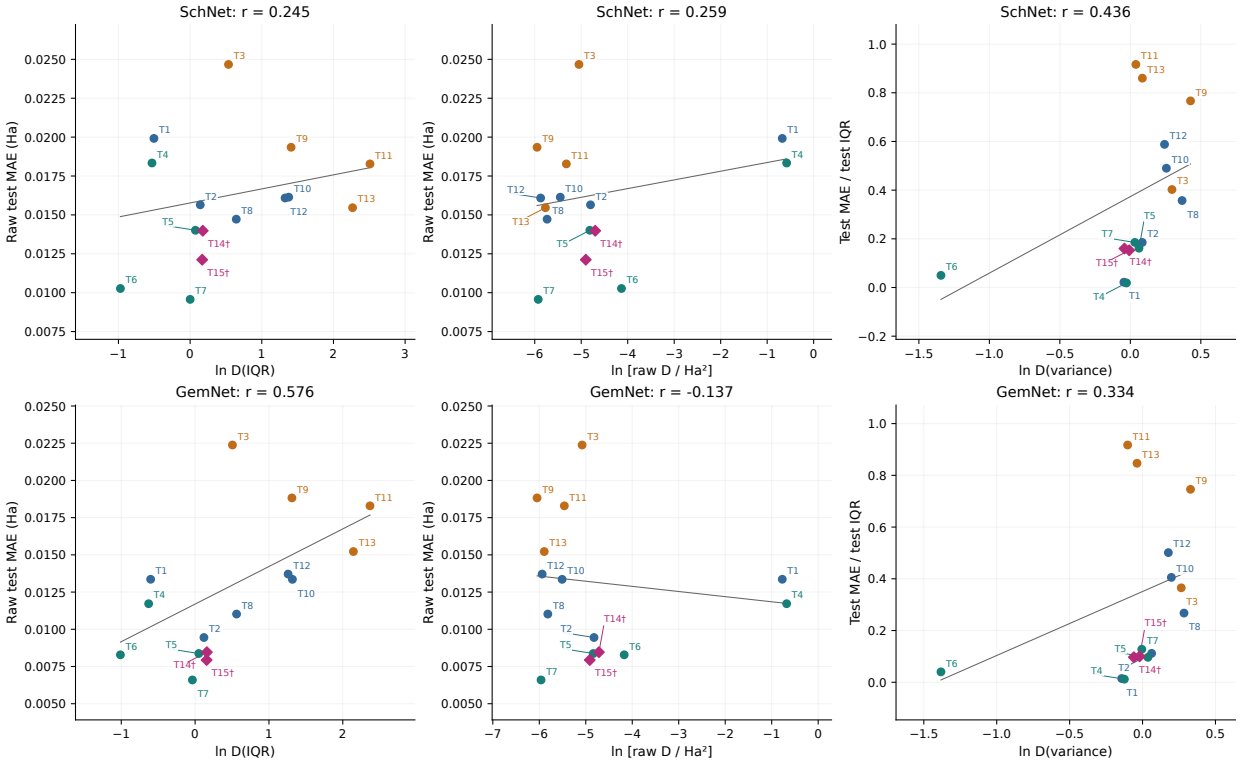



Figure S7: **Controls for shared normalization.** Columns use raw error with IQR-normalized roughness, neither axis IQR-normalized, and variance-normalized roughness with IQR-normalized error. Lines and Pearson $r$ use only the 13 main targets. DFTB† remains a visual control.

The strongest association is not invariant to these choices. With raw error instead of $n$-MAE, $R^2$ falls to 0.060 for SchNet and 0.332 for GemNet. With neither axis IQR-normalized, $R^2$ is 0.067 and 0.019. The normalized fit must not be presented as equally strong evidence that unnormalized roughness predicts absolute error independently of target scale.

Using the same test cohort makes the comparison internally consistent, but does not eliminate shared-denominator coupling. As another descriptive check, we linearly residualize $\ln D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ and $\ln n$-MAE against $\ln \mathrm{IQR}_{\mathrm{test}}$, including an intercept, and correlate the residual vectors. Partial Pearson correlations are 0.640 and 0.690. This checks association beyond a linear log-scale trend, but does not establish causality or a universal error law in a small, related target panel.

The association table also reports narrower panels: the DFT-BoE parent and its seven non-DFTB residuals, and the six descriptor residuals alone. Leaving out each main target in turn gives semi-log $R^2$ ranges of 0.927–0.965 for SchNet and 0.872–0.927 for GemNet. These are influence diagnostics, not cross-validated prediction scores.

**Molecular neighbourhood information beyond shared normalization**

A weaker raw correlation alone does not establish that the normalized association is artificial. We repeat the original control with 5,000 joint test-label permutations (seed 20260914), applying the same molecule permutation to all 13 targets and both architecture proxies. This preserves target distributions, IQRs, and cross-target relationships while disrupting label alignment with molecular neighbourhoods. Graphs, weights, and mean GNN test errors remain fixed; no GNN is retrained. DFTB is excluded. These controls are retrospective, not preregistered.

Table S11: **Corrected-test shared-normalization permutation control.** Fits use 13 primary targets per architecture. Null intervals are the 2.5th–97.5th percentiles over 5,000 joint molecule-label permutations, not confidence intervals for prediction. The one-sided $p$ uses signed Pearson $r$, not $R^2$.

| Model | Observed $R^2$ | Null median $R^2$ | Null 95% interval | $p$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| GemNet | 0.905 | 0.862 | 0.834–0.885 | 0.00020 |
| SchNet | 0.946 | 0.855 | 0.831–0.879 | 0.00020 |

For both models, the observed signed Pearson correlation of $\ln D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ with test $n$-MAE exceeds all 5,000 shuffled values: one-sided plus-one $p = 1/5001 \approx 0.00020$, conditional on this panel and randomization scheme, without adjustment for the two architecture comparisons. High shuffled median $R^2$ values (GemNet: 0.862; SchNet: 0.855) show that target distributions and normalization contribute substantially. The stronger observed associations support additional information from label–geometry alignment beyond this conditional null, not a purely physical explanation or universal learnability law. The observed-minus-shuffled $R^2$ is not a decomposition of explained variance.

Table S12: **All similar-test-IQR primary target pairs.** The larger IQR is at most 1.10 times the smaller; selection does not use roughness or errors. Values follow target order. Roughness uses PRE for SchNet and PRE+A for GemNet; normalized error is mean test MAE/test IQR. These descriptive comparisons are not independent confirmation on new data.

| Model | Targets | IQR (Ha) | $D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ | $n$-MAE |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| GemNet | $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}} \to E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.91832 → 0.97563 | 0.548 → 0.533 | 0.015 → 0.012 |
| GemNet | $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFT}} \to E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.08450 → 0.08677 | 1.127 → 1.051 | 0.112 → 0.096 |
| GemNet | $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}} \to \Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.02524 → 0.02735 | 3.711 → 3.524 | 0.746 → 0.501 |
| SchNet | $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}} \to E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.91832 → 0.97563 | 0.604 → 0.587 | 0.022 → 0.019 |
| SchNet | $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFT}} \to E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.08450 → 0.08677 | 1.152 → 1.077 | 0.185 → 0.161 |
| SchNet | $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}} \to \Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.02524 → 0.02735 | 4.092 → 3.763 | 0.767 → 0.588 |

The original 10% IQR-matching threshold selects three pairs, all concordant in roughness and normalized-error ordering for both models. Linear PRE+A has 8.4% larger IQR than MLP-BoB, but lower roughness and normalized error. Matching narrows, but does not eliminate, denominator differences. Together, these controls support a geometry-sensitive component while retaining the shared-normalization limitation; they do not establish causality.

# Supplementary Section 5: DFTB Semiempirical Control

## Supplementary Note 8: DFTB Coverage and Matched Evaluation

DFTB tests whether another semiempirical baseline can yield a useful residual. It remains a supporting control because successful calculations cover a different cohort and only seed 101 was trained. Of 71,038 neutral tmQM molecules, 362 lack successful DFTB calculations: 290 training, 36 validation, and 36 test molecules. Valid splits contain 56,540, 7,068, and 7,068 molecules. Ten QM9 DFTB failures leave 130,797 valid molecules. Failed energies are not imputed.

Raw DFTB calculations and fixed standard-molecule reference inputs were reused; the learned composition correction was newly fitted on successful tmQM training molecules only. Historical fitted residuals were not used. The DFT parent is the canonical train-only DFT-BoE target restricted to the valid mask. Frozen DFTB coefficients generate validation, test, and QM9 targets.

On common DFTB-valid test molecules, the residual's $D_{\mathrm{IQR}}$ is 1.184 in PRE and 1.169 in PRE+A, compared with 1.127 and 1.113 for the DFT parent under identical masks. This is a paired target-roughness comparison, not a comparison across different graph cohorts. The DFTB residual is slightly rougher than the parent in both proxies, despite improving matched-subset test MAE; lower normalized roughness is therefore not a necessary condition for lower absolute error. DFTB energy and residual GNNs reach test MAEs of 0.013980 and 0.012119 Ha for SchNet, and 0.008462 and 0.007936 Ha for GemNet. Direct DFTB energy and DFT residual remain different prediction tasks.

Table S13: Seed-101 DFT reconstruction on exactly matched DFTB-valid evaluation molecules (Ha). Shifted errors are oracle diagnostics. Training cohorts remain different: DFTB used only successful training molecules. These rows are not pooled into any primary analysis.

| Dataset | Route | N | S raw | S shifted | G raw | G shifted |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| tmqm | $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 7,068 | 0.015563 | 0.015623 | 0.009794 | 0.009832 |
| tmqm | $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 7,068 | 0.009499 | 0.009480 | 0.006538 | 0.006560 |
| tmqm | $\Delta^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 7,068 | 0.012119 | 0.012125 | 0.007936 | 0.007954 |
| qm9 | $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 130,797 | 0.252018 | 0.016036 | 0.255477 | 0.019912 |
| qm9 | $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 130,797 | 0.024872 | 0.006813 | 0.024622 | 0.006151 |
| qm9 | $\Delta^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 130,797 | 0.053349 | 0.011783 | 0.056495 | 0.012578 |

The matched table evaluates seed-101 direct-DFT, xTB-residual, and DFTB-residual predictors on identical DFTB-valid test or QM9 molecules. This removes evaluation-mask differences, but does not equalize their training cohorts. No separately trained exact-DFTB-mask direct-DFT GNN is included in the completed 82-run matrix. The control therefore supports a qualified comparison, not an unrestricted DFTB ranking or a three-seed uncertainty estimate.

# Supplementary Section 6: Independent-Seed Results

## Supplementary Note 9: GNN Seed Variation

The following tables report every main-run test and raw QM9 MAE, not only a representative seed. Each seed has its own validation-selected checkpoint. For $S = 3$, a metric $m_s$ is summarized by

$$\bar{m} = \frac{1}{S}\sum_s m_s, \qquad s_m = \sqrt{\frac{1}{S-1}\sum_s (m_s - \bar{m})^2}. \tag{S7}$$

This SD measures training-seed variation for a fixed dataset and target. It is not uncertainty from drawing new molecules, changing the baseline fitting seed, or selecting a different domain. Deterministic IQR and roughness values have no GNN-seed error bars.

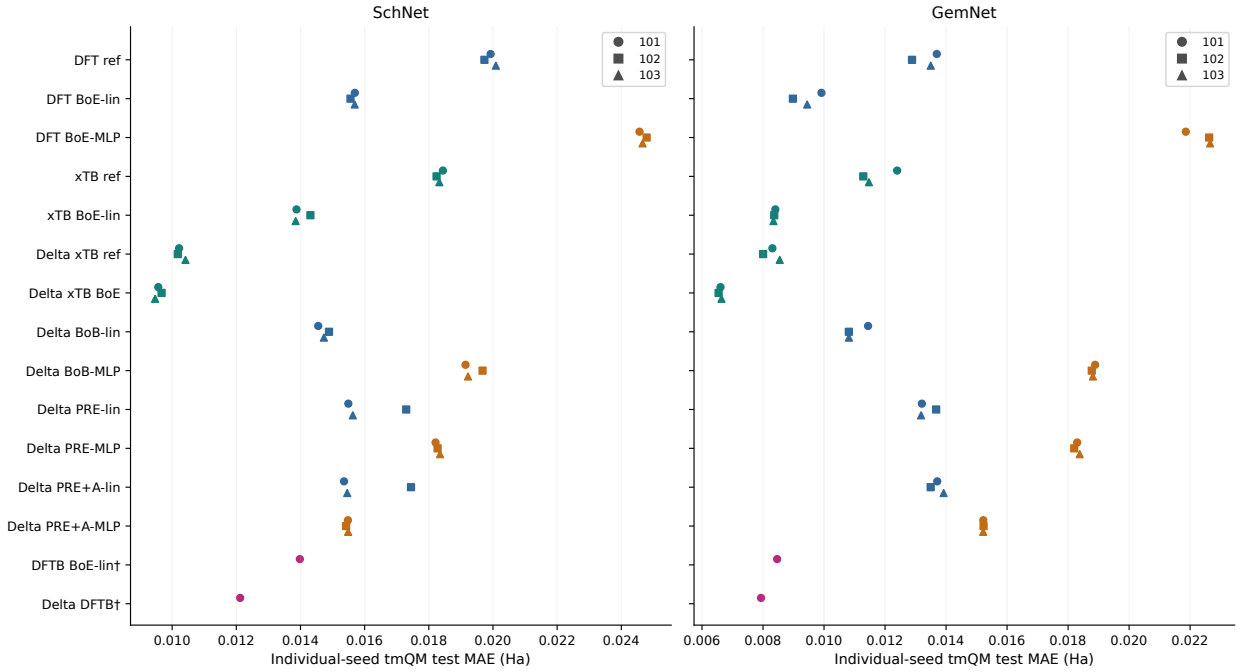



Figure S8: **Individual-seed tmQM test errors.** Circles, squares, and triangles show seeds 101, 102, and 103. All main targets have three runs per architecture. DFTB†, in magenta, has seed 101 only.

Table S14: SchNet individual-seed tmqm native-target MAEs (Ha). All predictions use each run's best-validation checkpoint. A dash denotes an intentionally unrun DFTB seed, not a zero error.

| Target | 101 | 102 | 103 |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref}}$ | 0.019928 | 0.019733 | 0.020089 |
| $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 0.015694 | 0.015559 | 0.015690 |
| $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}$ | 0.024566 | 0.024789 | 0.024662 |
| $E^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref}}$ | 0.018439 | 0.018242 | 0.018328 |
| $E^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 0.013876 | 0.014309 | 0.013849 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref}}$ | 0.010216 | 0.010176 | 0.010416 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 0.009568 | 0.009671 | 0.009469 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{BoB}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.014554 | 0.014888 | 0.014729 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{BoB}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.019145 | 0.019675 | 0.019222 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.015492 | 0.017296 | 0.015631 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.018210 | 0.018273 | 0.018350 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.015357 | 0.017444 | 0.015456 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.015479 | 0.015422 | 0.015485 |
| $E^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 0.013980 | – | – |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 0.012119 | – | – |

Table S15: GemNet individual-seed tmqm native-target MAEs (Ha). All predictions use each run's best-validation checkpoint. A dash denotes an intentionally unrun DFTB seed, not a zero error.

| Target | 101 | 102 | 103 |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref}}$ | 0.013696 | 0.012885 | 0.013498 |
| $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 0.009917 | 0.008979 | 0.009448 |
| $E^{\mathrm{DFT}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}$ | 0.021859 | 0.022624 | 0.022656 |
| $E^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref}}$ | 0.012397 | 0.011287 | 0.011471 |
| $E^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 0.008404 | 0.008368 | 0.008343 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref}}$ | 0.008307 | 0.008003 | 0.008548 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{xTB}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 0.006606 | 0.006544 | 0.006638 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{BoB}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.011443 | 0.010813 | 0.010816 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{BoB}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.018887 | 0.018777 | 0.018813 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.013208 | 0.013675 | 0.013182 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.018298 | 0.018200 | 0.018381 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}_{\mathrm{lin}}$ | 0.013711 | 0.013497 | 0.013921 |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}_{\mathrm{MLP}}$ | 0.015221 | 0.015229 | 0.015217 |
| $E^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}$ | 0.008462 | – | – |
| $\Delta^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}$ | 0.007936 | – | – |

Table S16: SchNet individual-seed qm9 native-target MAEs (Ha). All predictions use each run's best-validation checkpoint. A dash denotes an intentionally unrun DFTB seed, not a zero error.

| Target | 101 | 102 | 103 |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 1.006303 | 1.005030 | 1.015885 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.252019 | 0.258079 | 0.259814 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.483568 | 0.465546 | 0.471873 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.942838 | 0.944062 | 0.941814 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.274410 | 0.277747 | 0.271944 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.055792 | 0.055150 | 0.058758 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.024874 | 0.025531 | 0.021646 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.273621 | 0.279276 | 0.276816 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.261957 | 0.266765 | 0.263364 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.272982 | 0.277887 | 0.275026 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.213049 | 0.214906 | 0.214518 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.258401 | 0.256111 | 0.255926 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.215360 | 0.215299 | 0.215430 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.306405 | – | – |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.053349 | – | – |

Table S17: GemNet individual-seed qm9 native-target MAEs (Ha). All predictions use each run's best-validation checkpoint. A dash denotes an intentionally unrun DFTB seed, not a zero error.

| Target | 101 | 102 | 103 |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 1.055482 | 1.044236 | 1.080928 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.255478 | 0.244060 | 0.245231 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}MLP}}^{\mathrm{DFT}}$ | 0.476675 | 0.475178 | 0.483564 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.986678 | 0.992279 | 0.986614 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.283163 | 0.281808 | 0.276816 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.055135 | 0.054089 | 0.049559 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{xTB}}$ | 0.024624 | 0.025071 | 0.024750 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.262610 | 0.266210 | 0.267735 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{BoB}}$ | 0.257258 | 0.254821 | 0.246993 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.262614 | 0.263540 | 0.264543 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE}}$ | 0.213722 | 0.214740 | 0.215478 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{lin}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.253586 | 0.252567 | 0.257962 |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{MLP}}^{\mathrm{PRE+A}}$ | 0.214595 | 0.214208 | 0.215065 |
| $E_{\mathrm{ref,BoE\text{-}lin}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.306466 | – | – |
| $\Delta_{\mathrm{ref,BoE}}^{\mathrm{DFTB\dagger}}$ | 0.056495 | – | – |

SchNet linear PRE and PRE+A show larger test variability than most other targets. Their seed-102 test MAEs are 0.017296 and 0.017444 Ha, compared with approximately 0.0154–0.0156 Ha for the other seeds. These runs are retained rather than discarded. Differences between mean scores should not be described as decisive when comparable to this variation.

### Baseline Fitting Seeds Are Separate

A baseline-only check repeated each MLP fit with seeds 102 and 103, holding architecture, inputs, train-only preprocessing, and checkpoint selection fixed. Baseline seed 101 remains canonical; predictions and residual targets were not averaged over fitting seeds.

Table S18: Separate MLP-baseline fitting-seed check (Ha), seeds 101, 102, and 103. These are not the GNN seeds. Only baseline seed 101 defines the targets used by the 78 main GNN runs.

| Descriptor | Test MAE | Range |
|---|---|---|
| BOB | 0.021219 ± 0.000092 | 0.021124–0.021307 |
| BOE | 0.045442 ± 0.000512 | 0.044907–0.045926 |
| PRE | 0.018639 ± 0.000120 | 0.018509–0.018746 |
| PRE+A | 0.016523 ± 0.000201 | 0.016335–0.016735 |

Baseline test MAE SD is below 0.0006 Ha in each family, but individual residual labels are not identical. Paired test residuals show rare large differences relative to the canonical fit, with maxima of 1.093 Ha for PRE and 0.866 Ha for PRE+A. These scores use the already stored, frozen test predictions without refitting or selecting among baseline seeds. The present GNN error bars do not quantify this additional variability. Robustness to baseline fitting seed would require downstream evaluation on those alternative targets.

## Supplementary Section 7: Target Normalization Values and Prediction Audit

Training means and population standard deviations agreed with the settings recorded in all 82 model configurations.

Table S19: Target scales in Ha. Training means and population standard deviations were independently checked against all 82 configuration files and remain unchanged. Test IQR normalizes reported test errors and test-graph roughness; it is not used for training.

| Target | $\mu_{\text{train}}$ | $\sigma_{\text{train}}$ | $\text{IQR}_{\text{test}}$ |
|---|---|---|---|
| $E_{\text{ref}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | 1.035182 | 0.733244 | 0.918321 |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | 0.000000 | 0.091165 | 0.084504 |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-MLP}}^{\text{DFT}}$ | 0.005657 | 0.065718 | 0.061288 |
| $E_{\text{ref}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | 0.986222 | 0.764581 | 0.975633 |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | 0.000000 | 0.095927 | 0.086765 |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | 0.048960 | 0.251295 | 0.205796 |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref,BoE}}^{\text{xTB}}$ | 0.000000 | 0.055191 | 0.051679 |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{BoB}}$ | 0.000000 | 0.051867 | 0.041208 |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{BoB}}$ | 0.001850 | 0.029471 | 0.025236 |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{PRE}}$ | -0.000000 | 0.040629 | 0.032934 |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{PRE}}$ | 0.001371 | 0.011373 | 0.019944 |
| $\Delta_{\text{lin}}^{\text{PRE+A}}$ | -0.000000 | 0.033210 | 0.027351 |
| $\Delta_{\text{MLP}}^{\text{PRE+A}}$ | 0.002017 | 0.010266 | 0.017979 |
| $E_{\text{ref,BoE-lin}}^{\text{DFTB†}}$ | 0.000000 | 0.097167 | 0.087331 |
| $\Delta_{\text{ref,BoE}}^{\text{DFTB†}}$ | -0.000748 | 0.085898 | 0.079243 |

The primary test graphs contained 51,535 PRE edges and 53,533 PRE+A edges. The DFTB-valid graphs contained 51,268 and 53,246 edges, respectively.

All 164 recomputed native-target MAEs agreed with the final ledgers to within $6.7 \times 10^{-16}$ Ha. All split-file checksums matched the target registry, all split molecule sets were disjoint, and the tmQM and QM9 predictions used matching checkpoints. The release includes target and prediction manifests, checksums, and machine-readable evaluation summaries [1].

## References


[1] Kareem M. Gameel, Ihor Neporozhnii, Sjoerd Hoogland, and Oleksandr Voznyy. The mechanics of delta learning: Corrected code and data release. https://github.com/kareem-gameel/delta-learning-target-design/releases/tag/v0.2.0-corrected, 2026. Version v0.2.0-corrected.